

SERIES

Europe's choices

All the pieces in the series in a single document, in reading order. Updated 18 October 2026.

The choices of Europe's leaders measured against the facts: who Europe depends on for energy, who builds the electric car, what is left of the market with Russia, how the war in Ukraine came about, what Europe chose after 2022, why Ukraine counts for more than Sudan, who really decides Europe's choices, whether Nord Stream was a military objective and which doors Europe closes and opens to migrants. In every piece the facts are kept apart from our assessment.

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1/9 · ANALYSIS · 10 OCTOBER 2026

Europe stopped depending on Moscow. Who does it depend on now?

IN BRIEF

- In 2021 Russia supplied over **45%** of the gas imported by the European Union; in 2025 about **13%**.
- Today the largest supplier is Norway, with about **30%**. The United States supplies **58% of liquefied gas**, about **a quarter** of all the gas consumed in Europe.
- European households pay on average **almost twice** as much for gas as in early 2021: from 6.4 to 12.3 cents per kWh.
- In 2025 American liquefied gas was, on average, the most expensive of those bought by Europe.
- On 9 October Trump suspended sanctions on Russian diesel until April 2027.
- The trial over the Nord Stream sabotage opens in Hamburg on **14 October**.

Europe is entering winter with its lowest gas reserves in almost twenty years: at the end of August storage was about 63% full (Oilprice, 27/8/2026, based on Gas Infrastructure Europe data). Qatari gas, blocked at Hormuz, has almost disappeared (see the Hormuz crisis).

Europe suffered this part of the crisis. But its fragility in the face of such a shock stems from a choice made four years ago. This is the first piece in a series on the major choices of Europe's leadership: for each one we ask what was decided, what alternatives existed, what it cost and what worked.

THE CHOICE OF 2022

After the invasion of Ukraine, the Union decided to exit Russian gas. The choice was not entirely free. In the summer of 2022 it was Moscow that cut Nord Stream flows to a fifth of capacity (Bloomberg, 25/7/2022), and in September the pipeline was destroyed.

The exit is now written into a regulation, 2026/261 (EUR-Lex). Short-term contracts are already banned: since 25 April 2026 for liquefied gas, since 17 June for pipeline gas. Long-term contracts end on 1 January 2027 for liquefied gas and on 30 September 2027 for pipeline gas.

The question is how that gas was replaced. In 2021 Russia accounted for over 45% of European imports; in 2024, 19%; in 2025 about 13%, according to Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen (ANSA via Il Nordest, 24/4/2025). Today the largest supplier is Norway, with about 30% (European Commission, quarterly gas report, Q2 2025). The rest arrives mainly by ship, as liquefied gas, and 58% of that gas comes from the United States: about a quarter of all European demand (ACER, 2026).

The dependence on Moscow is over; the dependence on the sea, and on Washington, has begun. In July 2025, in the trade deal with Trump, the Union also pledged to buy 750 billion dollars of American energy over three years: a political, non-binding commitment that many analysts consider unachievable (Oil & Gas 360, 28/7/2025).

HOW MUCH WE PAY

Liquefied gas is more expensive by nature: it has to be cooled, shipped and regasified. But there is more to it. In the second quarter of 2025 gas in the United States cost 13.7 euros per megawatt-hour; once in Europe it cost 35.5 (European Commission, report cited above). That gap covers the costs, and the margins of those who sell. According to IEEFA, in 2025 American liquefied gas was on average the most expensive for European buyers, ahead of Qatari and Russian gas; from 2022 to 2025 the Union bought 131.5 billion euros' worth of it (IEEFA, European LNG Tracker). IEEFA is an American non-profit institute, funded by philanthropic foundations, which states that it supports the transition to clean energy.

On the bill, the European average for households, taxes included, looks like this:

	First half of 2021	Second half of 2025
Average EU household gas price (cents per kWh)	6.4	12.28
Example: a home using 10,000 kWh a year	about €640	about €1,230

Sources: Eurostat, 5/5/2026 for 2025; Eurostat figure for 2021 reported by Euronews, 26/2/2026. The example is our own calculation on an indicative consumption level; differences between countries are very large.

The price has almost doubled, and the late-2025 figures do not yet include the Gulf war: between February and April 2026 gas in European capitals rose by a further 6.8% (Euronews, 14/5/2026, HEPI index). It must be said, however, that wholesale prices had already started to soar in the second half of 2021, months before the invasion, with the post-pandemic recovery (World Bank, monthly series): the crisis does not stem from European choices alone.

WHILE WASHINGTON NEGOTIATES WITH MOSCOW

Europe has set a date to give up Russian gas, and until then keeps buying it; its main ally is going in the opposite direction. On 9 October Trump announced a deal with Putin to receive Russian diesel: over 300,000 tonnes immediately, then growing quantities up to a few million. The US Treasury issued a licence suspending until April 2027 the sanctions on Russian diesel already loaded on ships (OPB, 9/10/2026). Zelensky called it “a weak decision” by strong partners.

On 8 October Reuters reported that envoy Jared Kushner and Kirill Dmitriev, an adviser to Putin, had discussed bringing an American investor into Nord Stream (Reuters via WHBL, 8/10/2026). The White House says it has not been discussed recently; Berlin says a reopening is “not desired”. The pipelines are under European sanctions: under EU law a restart would remain illegal, whatever Washington decides.

WHO DESTROYED NORD STREAM

On 14 October the trial of Serhii Kuznietsov opens in Hamburg. A Ukrainian citizen extradited from Italy, he is accused of leading the group of seven people who planted the charges. According to German investigators, the order came from a Ukrainian state agency, to deprive Moscow of gas revenues. Kyiv denies it; Zelensky has said he knew nothing about it (JusticeInfo). A second suspect, Volodymyr Zhuravlyov, was arrested in Croatia in August, after a Polish court had refused his extradition (LIGA, 19/8/2026). The theories circulated in recent years blaming the United States or Russia itself have not been borne out by any judicial investigation. The charges, in any case, have yet to be proven in court.

WHAT WORKED

In 2022 many predicted rationing and closed factories. It did not happen: Europe replaced most Russian gas in three years and stopped being open to blackmail by a supplier that used deliveries as a weapon. That is a real achievement. The price was a bill that has almost doubled and a new dependence, more expensive and more exposed to distant crises.

OUR ASSESSMENT

Leaving Russian gas was a defensible choice: no country should entrust the heating of its homes to a state that has just invaded a neighbour. The mistake was doing it without building real autonomy. Europe changed supplier, not condition. It tied a quarter of its gas to a single country, promised to buy even more, and now finds that this country is negotiating with Moscow on its own, on diesel and perhaps on Nord Stream, while European households pay the

bill. A leadership able to choose, in a time of transition, should have asked not only whom to stop buying from, but whom never again to depend on so heavily.

> **Update, 11 October 2026.** According to the German organisation Urgewald, using data from the analytics firm Kpler, between January and September 2026 EU ports received 12.18 million tonnes of Russian liquefied gas from the Arctic Yamal project: 9.5% more than in the same period of 2025, a record. Of Yamal's deliveries, 85% end up in Europe; in September almost three quarters of those reaching the Union were unloaded in France, at Dunkirk and Montoir (Euronews). Urgewald estimates their value at about €7.9 billion, but warns that this is a calculation based on market prices, not the sum of actual payments or of Russian state revenue. In the third quarter deliveries fell by 13.6% year on year. The purchases are legal: short-term contracts have been banned since April, long-term ones will be from 1 January 2027. For this reason we have corrected the sentence that opened the section “While Washington negotiates with Moscow”, which said Europe “is giving up” Russian gas: it will, but for now it is still buying it.

> **Update, 15 October 2026.** The trial opened on 14 October before the Hamburg Higher Regional Court and is expected to run until early 2027. According to the prosecution, Kuznietsov and other Ukrainian servicemen acted on orders from Ukrainian state agencies; the defendant denies this and did not speak in court (Courthouse News). The defence argues that there is no evidence of his involvement and, at the same time, that the pipeline was a legitimate military target, “a weapon in the hands of the Russians”. The court will therefore have to decide whether this was an attack on civilian infrastructure, prohibited by the law of war, or a military operation. According to the BBC, in September 2022 Kuznietsov was on active duty in the Ukrainian armed forces (LIGA, citing the BBC). Ukraine's Prosecutor General says it has found no evidence of state involvement (Kyiv Independent).

WHAT TO WATCH

- Gas storage levels on 1 November and the Hamburg trial, from 14 October.
- Deliveries of Russian diesel to the United States and the talks on Nord Stream and Lukoil.
- Eurostat household bill data for the first half of 2026, expected at the end of October.

Sources: Oilprice, 27/8/2026 · Bloomberg, 25/7/2022 · EUR-Lex · ANSA via Il Nordest, 24/4/2025 · European Commission, quarterly gas report, Q2 2025 · ACER, 2026 · Oil & Gas 360, 28/7/2025 · IEEFA, European LNG Tracker · Eurostat, 5/5/2026 · Euronews, 26/2/2026 · Euronews, 14/5/2026 · World Bank,

monthly series · OPB, 9/10/2026 · Reuters via WHBL, 8/10/2026 · JusticeInfo · LIGA, 19/8/2026 · Urgewald, 9/10/2026 · Euronews, 9/10/2026 · Courthouse News, 14/10/2026 · LIGA, citing the BBC, 10/10/2026 · Kyiv Independent, 9/7/2026

Europe chose the electric car. Who builds it?

IN BRIEF

- In August 2026 Chinese brands held **11.7%** of new car registrations in Europe, up from 7.1% a year earlier.
- Since 2024 the EU has imposed duties of up to 35.3% on Chinese electric cars, but **not on hybrids**: Chinese hybrid exports to the EU rose from about 3,800 cars a month (October 2024) to about 50,000 (July 2026).
- After the 9 October understanding with Beijing, the EU is preparing a **cap of 350,000 Chinese hybrids a year**, possibly from December. For Brussels it is half of what would have arrived; for Beijing it is 16% more than in 2025.
- On 15-16 October EU leaders took no decision on the cap, but asked for trade defence instruments to be strengthened "urgently", **without naming China**.
- The ban on selling petrol and diesel cars from 2035 is under review.
- Northvolt, Europe's battery champion, went bankrupt in 2025; European car suppliers announced **104,000 job cuts** in two years.
- The EU spends **2.2%** of GDP on research, a share that has not moved in ten years; China has reached **2.8%**.

On 9 October Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič came back from Beijing with a "shared understanding": China is to slow its exports of hybrid cars to Europe (Eunews, 9/10/2026). Three days later the numbers came out: a cap of 350,000 Chinese hybrids a year, plug-ins included, rising by 6% a year for four years and possibly starting as early as December (euperspectives, 13/10/2026).

The same number can be read two ways. For the Commission, without a cap 800,000 Chinese hybrids would have arrived this year: exports are halved. For Beijing, 302,000 arrived in 2025: the cap leaves room for 16% growth (euperspectives, cited). On 16 October China's Commerce Ministry called the understanding "reciprocal and mutually beneficial", reached under WTO rules and the principle of non-discrimination, and said the idea that "European pressure worked" was "groundless" (Chinese Commerce Ministry via The Paper, 16/10/2026).

EU leaders, meeting in Brussels on 15 and 16 October, took no decision on the cap, which the Commission can launch on its own. China is not named in the conclusions: they refer to "global macroeconomic imbalances" and call for the EU toolbox to be "urgently" strengthened with

new instruments (European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026). According to officials quoted by Euronews, over lunch the leaders called for safeguards with quotas and tariffs for chemicals and machinery as well. “The competition must be fair,” said German Chancellor Friedrich Merz. “The toolbox will be bigger” (Euronews, 16/10/2026). Hybrids thus become the test case for a tougher trade policy towards China.

Meanwhile the numbers keep running: in August Chinese brands sold almost 98,000 cars in Europe, 11.7% of the market, against 7.1% a year earlier (ChinaEVHome on Dataforce data, 24/9/2026). This is the second piece in the series on the choices of Europe's leaders.

THE CHOICE: A DATE WITHOUT A ROAD

In 2023 the Union decided by law that from 2035 new cars must emit no CO2: in practice, the end of the petrol and diesel engine (Regulation (EU) 2023/851). Part of the industry wanted freedom of technology; under German pressure, only engines running on synthetic fuels were spared (Euronews, 28/3/2023).

The problem was not the direction but what was missing to get there. The heart of an electric car is the battery, and the supply chain for batteries and raw materials is largely Chinese. Sweden's Northvolt, Europe's most ambitious attempt, went bankrupt in March 2025 (E&E News). And in the 9 October understanding Beijing also promised to keep easing export licences for rare earths and magnets (The Next Web, 12/10/2026): a sign of who depends on whom.

In December 2025 the Commission proposed a change of course: a 90% cut in emissions instead of 100%, with hybrids and combustion engines still on sale after 2035 (Automotive World). Member states are divided; the European Parliament votes in November (Council of the EU, 15/6/2026).

THE DEFENCE: DUTIES ON ONE DOOR, THE OTHER LEFT OPEN

Since October 2024 the Union has applied anti-subsidy duties to electric cars made in China, on top of the ordinary 10% duty:

Manufacturer	Extra duty on electric cars
BYD	17%
Geely	18.8%
SAIC (MG)	35.3%

Source: New Mobility, 22/6/2026. Since January 2026 manufacturers can offer a minimum price and a volume cap instead (Caixin, 13/1/2026).

But the duties only hit fully electric cars, and Chinese manufacturers shifted to hybrids. Their hybrid exports to the EU rose from about 3,800 cars in October 2024 to about 50,000 in July 2026 (EUobserver, 5/10/2026). In the first half of 2026 Chinese brands held 28.3% of the European plug-in hybrid market, according to Dataforce (New Mobility, cited). For Volkswagen's chief executive, Oliver Blume, the duties work, but “not with hybrids” (The Next Web, 27/7/2026).

This contradicts a common reading: the Chinese did not get in only thanks to the electric mandate. They also got in, more and more, through the hybrid door.

WHAT TRADE LAW SAYS

The 2024 duties are lawful: WTO rules allow duties against state subsidies, decided after an investigation (Implementing Regulation (EU) 2024/2754). But that investigation did not cover hybrids, as Šefčovič himself acknowledged (Diplomacy and Law, 9/10/2026).

For hybrids there were two roads. The first was for Beijing to rein in its own exports: a “voluntary restraint”, the tool Japan used in the 1980s to limit its own cars, and which the WTO has banned since 1994 (Agreement on Safeguards, Art. 11). Brussels chose the second: a “safeguard”, that is, a cap set by the EU itself. The rules allow it, on three conditions: proving serious injury to European industry, applying the cap to all countries of origin rather than one, and limiting it in time. Country quotas can be agreed with the main suppliers (Art. 5), and that appears to be the road taken with Beijing.

Formally, then, the cap covers hybrids from every source, Japanese or Korean ones included, but the quotas for other suppliers have not yet been set. At first it would apply provisionally for 200 days; then member states would vote by qualified majority. Chinese-brand cars assembled inside the EU, for example in Hungary, stay out of the count (euperspectives, cited). The legal text is not yet public: it remains to be seen how the Commission will prove serious injury.

THE FACTORIES ARRIVE, THE TECHNOLOGY STAYS IN CHINA

Chinese manufacturers now also produce in Europe, partly to avoid the duties. Chery will start in Barcelona, in the former Nissan plant, between late 2026 and early 2027; Leapmotor will produce in Spain with Stellantis; SAIC is planning a plant in Galicia (Reuters via MarketScreener, 2/6/2026). And cars assembled in Europe stay outside the cap. The factories create jobs, but design, software and batteries stay with those who developed them.

Meanwhile the European supply chain is shrinking: car suppliers announced 54,000 job cuts in 2024 and 50,000 in 2025, against about 7,000 hires (CLEPA via Just Auto, 19/1/2026).

A LAG THAT GOES BACK FURTHER

Duties defend a market, but they do not create an industry. And the gap with China opened well before 2023. In 2024 the Union spent 2.2% of GDP on research, almost the same share as ten years earlier and far from the 3% target (Eurostat, 4/12/2025). In 2025 China reached 2.8%, above the average of the rich OECD countries (South China Morning Post, 30/9/2026).

There is another side too. Protecting oneself is not a European whim: for decades China forced foreign carmakers to produce only in joint ventures with a Chinese partner, and lifted the requirement only in 2022 (Gasgoo, 2021). Protecting oneself is not a sign of weakness. It becomes one when it is the only thing one knows how to do.

WHAT WORKED

The duties on electric cars curbed imports where they were applied, as European carmakers themselves admit. And electric cars now sell: in August 2026 they were 29.2% of European registrations (ChinaEVHome on ACEA data, cited). The market moved in the direction decided in 2023; what was missing were the tools to make sure Europeans gained from it.

OUR ASSESSMENT

Betting on electric was not a mistake: the world is going that way, and China understood it first. The mistake was setting the destination without building the road. Europe did not secure batteries, raw materials and software; it closed the electric door and left the hybrid door open for two years; and now it closes it with a cap that buys time, not competitiveness. That time is only useful if it is used. Yet for ten years Europe has not raised its research spending, and at the October summit the leaders “urgently” asked for new defensive instruments, while for cars they stopped at a package simplifying the rules. Without an industry able to invent, duties and caps become an admission of weakness, not a strategy. It is the same plot as energy: right goals, wrong dependencies.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The legal text of the safeguard: how the Commission will prove serious injury, the quotas for Japan, Korea and other suppliers, the start date.

- Beijing's response: the Commerce Ministry warns the EU “not to underestimate” China's determination to defend its interests.
- The new trade defence instruments the leaders asked for, and whether they will be ready by the end of the year; the automotive package, which the leaders want concluded by December.
- The European Parliament's vote on 2035, in November, and the start of Chinese production in Spain.

Sources: Eunews, 9/10/2026 · euperspectives, 13/10/2026 · Chinese Commerce Ministry via The Paper, 16/10/2026 · European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026 · Euronews, 16/10/2026 · ChinaEVHome on Dataforce data, 24/9/2026 · Regulation (EU) 2023/851 · Euronews, 28/3/2023 · E&E News · The Next Web, 12/10/2026 · Automotive World · Council of the EU, 15/6/2026 · New Mobility, 22/6/2026 · Caixin, 13/1/2026 · EUobserver, 5/10/2026 · The Next Web, 27/7/2026 · Diplomacy and Law, 9/10/2026 · Agreement on Safeguards, Art. 11 · Reuters via MarketScreener, 2/6/2026 · CLEPA via Just Auto, 19/1/2026 · Eurostat, 4/12/2025 · South China Morning Post, 30/9/2026 · Gasgoo, 2021

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The Euro-Russian market that worried Washington: what the numbers say

IN BRIEF

- Trade between the European Union and Russia **peaked in 2012** and then fell: by 2021, before the invasion, it was already almost a quarter lower.
- In 2021 Russia was the fifth market for European goods; **62%** of what Europe bought from Moscow was energy.
- The United States openly opposed Nord Stream 2, with sanctions in **2019** and with Biden's promise of **7 February 2022**.
- Today the Union takes more than half of American liquefied gas, and **58%** of the weapons imported by Europe's NATO members come from the United States.
- Over the same period Europe resumed selling weapons to Saudi Arabia and called Azerbaijan's gas "reliable".

A RECURRING THESIS

In public debate, in Italy and elsewhere, one idea keeps coming back: before the war a great market was taking shape between Europe and Russia, European industry joined with Russian raw materials. A prospect that would have weakened the United States, and that Washington would have had an interest in stopping.

The idea has a true part and a part the numbers do not confirm. Here we separate them. This is the third piece in the series on the choices of Europe's leadership, after the one on energy.

THE DREAM "FROM LISBON TO VLADIVOSTOK"

The project has a date. On 25 November 2010 Vladimir Putin, then prime minister, proposed in a German newspaper a great economic space "from Lisbon to Vladivostok", with a free-trade area (Moscow Times, 25/11/2010).

Berlin answered cautiously: Angela Merkel said she shared the idea, but that Russia was not moving in that direction (AFP via bilaterals.org). The project never went beyond statements.

And the dollar? In 2019 Rosneft, Russia's largest oil company, switched all its export contracts from the dollar to the euro, to shield itself from American sanctions (High North News, citing

Reuters).

WHAT THE NUMBERS SAY

EU–Russia trade in goods (€ billion)	2002	2012	2021	2025
Imports from Russia	61	204	158	27
Exports to Russia	33	118	89	30

Sources: Eurostat, 7/3/2022 for 2012 and 2021; for 2002, Eurostat data reported by Chronicle.lu; for 2025, Eurostat Comext data reported by The Trade Hub, consistent with the quarterly data from Eurostat.

Trade grew until 2012, then fell with the Crimea crisis, the first sanctions and the drop in oil prices. In 2021 Russia accounted for 4.1% of European exports and 7.5% of imports, and 62% of what Europe bought from Moscow was energy (Eurostat, cited above).

It was an important relationship but a simple one: Russian raw materials in exchange for European machinery. And before the war it was already shrinking. Russia's GDP, $1,830 billion, was about a tenth of the Union's, $17,300 billion (World Bank via FRED). Talk of an economic "empire" in the making finds no support in the data.

WHO HAD OPPOSING INTERESTS

American interests, on the other hand, are documented.

On 20 December 2019 Trump signed a law sanctioning the companies laying Nord Stream 2. A few hours later the Swiss-Dutch company Allseas suspended work (Reuters via PGJ). The German government said it rejected "extraterritorial" sanctions (EUobserver).

On 7 February 2022, next to Chancellor Scholz, Biden said that in case of an invasion Nord Stream 2 would be finished. Scholz avoided naming the pipeline (CNBC, 7/2/2022).

After 2022, who gained can be measured:

- **Gas.** In 2025, 54% of the liquefied gas exported by the United States went to the Union, 63% more than the year before (Banchero Costa via Hellenic Shipping News). The energy piece in this series showed at what price.
- **Weapons.** Between 2021 and 2025 the United States supplied 58% of the weapons imported by Europe's NATO members (SIPRI via Defense News, 9/3/2026).

On the dollar, by contrast, the war did not change the trend. In 1999 it made up 71% of central bank reserves; today it is at 56.7%, while the euro has risen to 20.6% (IMF, 30/9/2026).

AN INTEREST IS NOT A CAUSE

Having an interest does not mean having caused an event. The full-scale war began on 24 February 2022, when Russian troops entered Ukraine. On 2 March the UN General Assembly demanded their withdrawal with 141 votes in favour (UN, resolution ES-11/1). On 16 March the International Court of Justice ordered Russia to suspend its military operations (ICJ, order). How we got to that day, with everyone's responsibilities, is the subject of the next piece.

THE MORAL BILL

There is one point where the criticism of Europe fully holds. While giving up Russia in the name of principles, the Union built other relationships with fewer scruples:

- On 18 July 2022 Commission President von der Leyen signed an agreement in Baku to double gas from Azerbaijan by 2027, calling the country a reliable partner (European Commission, IP/22/4550). A year later Azerbaijan took Nagorno-Karabakh with a military offensive, and more than a hundred thousand Armenians fled to Armenia (UNHCR, via Reuters).
- On 31 May 2023 Italy lifted the ban on selling bombs and missiles to Saudi Arabia, imposed over the war in Yemen (Reuters via The New Arab).
- In January 2024 Germany dropped its veto on Eurofighters for Riyadh, citing the Saudi attitude towards Israel after 7 October (AP via PBS).

WHAT WORKED

Cutting trade took away the lever Moscow had used for years to influence European governments. Since the second quarter of 2025 the Union has had a trade surplus with Russia, for the first time in more than twenty years (Euronews, 30/8/2025; Eurostat via Sofia Globe, 24/2/2026). A Europe that in 2021 bought 45% of its imported gas from a single country was exposed to blackmail; today it is much less so.

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Those who argue that the United States had an interest in separating Europe from Russia are right: Washington said so and acted on it, with the Nord Stream sanctions and with Biden's

promise. Those who argue that for this reason America "made the war break out" confuse an interest with a cause, and erase the choice of whoever sent in the tanks. The Euro-Russian market was not killed in 2022: it had stalled ten years earlier, when Moscow preferred Crimea to free trade.

One fact weighs more than intentions. Whatever the cause of the war, its outcome left Europe with no alternative and made it more dependent on Washington, its main beneficiary. But the Russian alternative was itself a dependence. A sovereign Europe should have built its own autonomy, not chosen between two masters.

And there is the double standard. The Union broke with Moscow in the name of principles, but at the same time resumed selling weapons to those who had bombed Yemen and called reliable a government that a year later would settle a conflict by force. Principles applied only to the enemy of the moment are not principles: they are convenience.

WHAT TO WATCH

- Eurostat data on trade with Russia in 2026 and the 23rd sanctions package.
- The $750 billion commitment to American energy: how much of it has actually been bought.
- The review of the EU common position on arms exports.

Sources: Moscow Times, 25/11/2010 · AFP via bilaterals.org · High North News, citing Reuters · Eurostat, 7/3/2022 · Chronicle.lu · The Trade Hub · Eurostat · World Bank via FRED · Reuters via PGJ · EUobserver · CNBC, 7/2/2022 · Banchero Costa via Hellenic Shipping News · SIPRI via Defense News, 9/3/2026 · IMF, 30/9/2026 · UN, resolution ES-11/1 · ICJ, order · European Commission, IP/22/4550 · UNHCR, via Reuters · Reuters via The New Arab · AP via PBS · Euronews, 30/8/2025 · Eurostat via Sofia Globe, 24/2/2026

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From 1990 to 2022: how the war in Ukraine came about

IN BRIEF

- In 1990 Western leaders verbally assured Gorbachev that NATO would not expand eastwards. **They never put it in writing.**
- Russia has signed several times the **right of every state to choose its own alliances**, and in 1994 it guaranteed Ukraine's borders.
- The political clash begins around **2007-2008**. The rupture comes in **2013-2014**, when Europe and Russia compete for Ukraine's economy.
- Ukraine's far right existed and was armed, but it never won more than **5%** at the polls.
- The war in Donbas killed about **14,300 people** in eight years. According to the European Court of Human Rights, Russia controlled the separatist areas **from May 2014**.

WHY THIS PIECE

The full-scale war begins on 24 February 2022, but the rupture between Europe and Russia goes back a long way. The previous piece distinguished between those who had an interest in that rupture and those who caused it. Here we set out thirty years in order, with one rule: for every fact that is uncomfortable for one side, we also look for those uncomfortable for the other, and we give the floor first to courts and international observers, then to governments.

1990: THE VERBAL PROMISE

On 9 February 1990 US Secretary of State James Baker told Gorbachev, three times, that NATO would not move "one inch" eastwards. Bush, Kohl, Mitterrand and Thatcher said similar things. This is shown by the documents published in 2017 by the National Security Archive.

But none of those statements ended up in a treaty. The treaty on German reunification only bans foreign NATO troops and nuclear weapons in the former East Germany. In 2014 Gorbachev himself said that eastward enlargement was not discussed in those years; he added, however, that the West had betrayed their spirit (German Federal Academy for Security Policy).

WHAT MOSCOW SIGNED

- **Helsinki 1975 and Istanbul 1999**: every state freely chooses its alliances. The Istanbul Charter adds that no one may strengthen its own security at the expense of others, the argument Moscow has always used, and that no one may consider any part of Europe its own "sphere of influence". Both are in the same paragraph.
- **Budapest 1994**: Ukraine gives up the ex-Soviet nuclear weapons; Russia, the United States and the United Kingdom undertake to respect its borders.
- **NATO–Russia Founding Act, 1997**: neither side has a veto over the other's decisions.

And it was the Eastern countries that asked to join NATO: Poland, Hungary, the Czech Republic and the Baltic states remembered Soviet invasions and occupations.

FROM COOPERATION TO CONFRONTATION

1999. Poland, Hungary and the Czech Republic join NATO. In the same year NATO bombs Serbia over Kosovo without UN approval. Moscow will not forget it.

2002. It is still a time of cooperation: the NATO–Russia Council is born. In those months, standing next to Ukrainian President Kuchma, Putin says that relations between Ukraine and NATO are "a matter for those two partners" (Kremlin).

2007-2008. In Munich Putin openly attacks the US-led order. Warnings also come from the West: back in 1997 the American diplomat George Kennan had called enlargement the gravest error of American policy since the Cold War (New York Times, 5/2/1997). In February 2008 the US ambassador in Moscow, William Burns, writes to Washington that Ukraine in NATO is the brightest red line for Russia's entire ruling class (cable published by WikiLeaks, Fair Observer).

In April, at the Bucharest summit, NATO announces that Ukraine and Georgia "will become members" (NATO, 3/4/2008), but Germany and France block the concrete path to membership. The result: Moscow feels threatened, Kyiv is left without protection. In August war breaks out in Georgia; an inquiry commissioned by the European Union will conclude that Tbilisi fired first, but that Russia's response went beyond the limits of self-defence (RTÉ, on the Tagliavini report).

Even then the road was not set: in 2010 the United States and Russia sign a new nuclear arms treaty, and in 2012 Russia joins the World Trade Organization, welcomed by Europe (EUI).

2013: TWO MARKETS FOR ONE COUNTRY

The real rupture comes from an economic dispute. Moscow wants Ukraine in its customs union; Brussels offers it a free-trade agreement. It cannot have both.

In August 2013 Russia blocks Ukrainian goods at the border for a week (OSW). An adviser to Putin calls signing with Europe "suicidal" (Reuters via Moscow Times). In November President Yanukovych gives up signing; on 17 December Moscow grants him $15 billion and a one-third discount on gas (Moscow Times). This is where the Maidan protests come from.

2014: MAIDAN, CRIMEA, DONBAS

Maidan. After three months of protests, Yanukovych flees in February. Between 18 and 20 February alone, in central Kyiv, 73 civilians and 11 police officers are killed (Hromadske). In early February a leaked phone call had already been released in which the American diplomat Victoria Nuland discussed with the ambassador who should join the government and swore at the European Union (MPR, citing AP): Washington wanted a say, and did not agree with Brussels.

The far right. It existed and was armed. The Azov battalion was founded in 2014 and its first commander came from a neo-Nazi group; in 2018 the US Congress banned funding it (The Hill, republished by Congressman Ro Khanna). But at the polls it carried little weight: in 2019 the entire far right, running together, won 2.15% and stayed out of parliament (Swedish Institute of International Affairs). The same year Zelensky, from a Jewish family, won with 73%.

Crimea and Donbas. In March Russia annexes Crimea; the UN General Assembly declares the referendum invalid, with 100 votes in favour, 11 against and 58 abstentions (Library of Congress). In April an armed group led by Igor Girkin, a former Russian intelligence officer, takes Sloviansk. Girkin will say he "pulled the trigger of the war", while admitting that by summer most fighters were local (Moscow Times). In 2025 the European Court of Human Rights ruled that Russia controlled the separatist areas from 11 May 2014, and that it is responsible for shooting down flight MH17 (ECHR, 9/7/2025).

Odesa. On 2 May clashes between pro-Ukrainian and pro-Russian groups leave 48 dead; 42 die in the fire at the Trade Unions House, where the pro-Russian activists had barricaded themselves (Kyiv Post). In 2025 the European Court found against Ukraine for failing to prevent the violence, rescue the victims and investigate properly (ECHR, 13/3/2025).

The dead. From 2014 to 2021 the UN counts about 14,300 dead, at least 3,404 of them civilians, most in the first two years (OHCHR).

MINSK: AN AGREEMENT NOBODY KEPT

The Minsk agreements (2014-2015) provided for a ceasefire, the withdrawal of weapons and foreign forces, and autonomy for Donbas. They were never implemented. In 2022 Merkel said

Minsk had also served to give Ukraine time to grow stronger (TASS, on Die Zeit): for Moscow this is proof of Western bad faith. But Russia never withdrew its forces, as the agreement required.

THE LAST WEEKS

In the days before the invasion OSCE monitors record a surge in shelling along the front: in Donetsk, between 18 and 20 February 2022, more than 2,100 ceasefire violations (OSCE). Each side blames the other.

Moscow justifies the invasion with an alleged "genocide" of Russian speakers in Donbas. In March 2022 the International Court of Justice says it has no evidence of that genocide (ICJ).

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Explaining is not justifying. The West gave verbal assurances and then disregarded them, ignored its own diplomats and in Bucharest chose the worst path: announcing membership without granting it. Washington tried to shape the government born of Maidan. In Ukraine the armed far right was tolerated for too long, and in Odesa the state failed. These are facts, and an honest account must include them.

But Russia had signed the right of every state to choose its alliances and had guaranteed Ukraine's borders. It used a trade blockade to stop Kyiv from making an economic choice, then took Crimea and Donbas. No Western mistake makes an invasion lawful: the UN Charter forbids the use of force to everyone, including those who feel threatened. It is the same yardstick we use for Washington, and it must be used for Moscow too.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The next piece in the series: Europe's choices after 2022 and what they have cost.
- The individual cases against Russia at the European Court of Human Rights, opened up by the July 2025 judgment.

Sources: National Security Archive · German Federal Academy for Security Policy · Istanbul Charter · Kremlin · New York Times, 5/2/1997 · Fair Observer · NATO, 3/4/2008 · RTÉ, on the Tagliavini report · EUI · OSW · Reuters via Moscow Times · Moscow Times · Hromadske · MPR, citing AP · The Hill,

republished by Congressman Ro Khanna · Swedish Institute of International Affairs · Library of Congress · Moscow Times · ECHR, 9/7/2025 · Kyiv Post · ECHR, 13/3/2025 · OHCHR · TASS, on Die Zeit · OSCE · ICJ

After 2022: what Europe chose and what it cost

IN BRIEF

- Since 2022 the Union has adopted **22 sanctions packages** against Russia; the latest, on 12 October 2026, targets 1,569 companies and executives in the military industry.
- In 2025, with US aid almost gone, Europe gave Kyiv about **€29 billion** in weapons and **€39 billion** in financial and humanitarian aid. For 2026-27 there is an EU loan of **€90 billion**.
- The costs: inflation at **10.6%** in October 2022, **€540 billion** in public support against high energy prices, output of Germany's energy-intensive industries down **15.2%**.
- Meanwhile Europe accepted US tariffs of **15%** on its goods, while removing its own on US industrial goods.
- The peace talks are led by the United States. The Europeans are consulted but do not lead; Moscow, for now, does not want to negotiate. At the summit of 16 October 2026 the 27 criticised Washington for halting sanctions on Russian diesel, but proposed no peace initiative of their own.
- Kyiv received tens of billions while a corruption scandal worth about **$100 million** broke out in the energy sector.

WHY THIS PIECE

The previous piece stopped on 24 February 2022. Here we look at what Europe decided after the invasion, what it cost and what weight it gave Europe. The UN Charter prohibits aggression, recognises the right to self-defence and asks everyone, before anything else, to seek a peaceful settlement. The question is which of these paths Europe chose, and who reaps the benefits.

THE CHOICES, ONE BY ONE

Choice	What	Who opted out
Sanctions	22 packages; almost 4,600 individuals and entities listed	nobody: every package requires unanimity
Money for Kyiv	EU loan of €90 billion for 2026-27, financed with joint debt	Hungary, Slovakia and the Czech Republic do not take part
Rearmament	NATO target of 5% of GDP by 2035; SAFE EU loans of €150 billion	Spain stops at 2.1%; Germany does not use SAFE
Refugees	temporary protection for 4.43 million Ukrainians, extended to March 2028	nobody
Ukraine's accession	four of six negotiating clusters opened between June and October 2026	Hungary's new government wants a referendum
Tariffs with the US	15% on European goods; zero tariffs on US industrial goods	—

Sources: Council of the EU, 12/10/2026; AP, 19/12/2025; Eunews, 23/6/2025; Grosswald, SAFE tracker; Eurostat via Eunews, 10/9/2026; Euronews, 10/7/2026; European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026.

THE DIPLOMACY THAT WAS MISSED

In the first weeks of the war there were real negotiations. At the end of March 2022, in Istanbul, the Russian and Ukrainian delegations agreed a communiqué: Ukrainian neutrality, with no nuclear weapons or foreign bases, in exchange for security guarantees from the great powers. By May the talks had broken off. Why is still debated: the discovery of the killings of civilians in Bucha weighed, as did Western reluctance to give binding guarantees and Russian demands on Crimea and on Ukraine's armed forces. The claim that the talks were stopped by British prime minister Johnson, who visited Kyiv on 9 April, is made by some and disputed by others (Foreign Affairs, 16/4/2024; The National Interest).

After 2022 the Union never opened a negotiating channel of its own with Moscow. Today the door is closed from the other side too: the Kremlin rejects a meeting between Putin and Zelensky outside Moscow (House of Commons Library, 15/9/2026) and, according to a source close to the Kremlin quoted by Reuters, Putin will return to talks only after taking the rest of Donbas (Meduza, 14/10/2026).

WHO PAYS

In 2025 Washington cut its aid to Kyiv by up to 99%. Europe filled the gap: about €29 billion in weapons, two thirds more than the 2022-2024 average, and €39 billion in financial and humanitarian aid, almost all from EU institutions. The burden is not evenly shared: northern countries gave a third of Europe's military aid with 8% of the donors' GDP; southern countries, Italy included, gave 3% with 19% of GDP (Kiel Institute via Euronews, 11/2/2026).

Part of that money goes back to the United States. Through the NATO mechanism called PURL, European governments buy American weapons for Ukraine: more than 90% of what passes through this channel comes from US stocks (Kiel Institute, 13/8/2026).

On frozen Russian assets the Union split. About €210 billion is blocked in Europe, most of it at Euroclear in Brussels. The plan to use it for a "reparations loan" collapsed in December 2025 because of opposition from Belgium, which feared lawsuits and risks for Euroclear. In its place came the €90 billion loan backed by joint debt: European taxpayers pay for it, while the assets stay frozen (AP, cited above).

WHERE THE MONEY GOES

On 22 July 2025 Ukraine's parliament passed, and Zelensky signed, a law stripping the two anti-corruption agencies, NABU and SAPO, of their independence. After days of street protests and European criticism, the law was reversed on 31 July (Euromaidan Press, 31/7/2025).

In November NABU made public Operation Midas: kickbacks of up to 15% on contracts at Energoatom, the state nuclear company, and about $100 million laundered. According to investigators, the scheme was run by Timur Mindich, a business partner of Zelensky, who fled before the charges. The justice and energy ministers were dismissed; on 28 November the head of the presidential office, Andriy Yermak, resigned on the day his home was searched (Euromaidan Press, 28/11/2025). The scandal came out because those agencies, saved by the street, did their job.

WHAT IT COST AT HOME

- **Prices.** In October 2022 euro area inflation hit 10.6%, a record, driven by energy (Eurostat).
- **Support against high energy prices.** Between September 2021 and June 2023 EU governments allocated €540 billion, €158 billion from Germany alone, mostly through across-the-board cuts in excise duties and VAT (Bruegel).

- **Sanctions and citizens.** Economic sanctions also hit people who bear no blame: a report presented to the UN documents how banks and companies, afraid of making mistakes, also block permitted trade, including medicines and humanitarian goods (UN, note by the Secretary-General). Russia's war economy, meanwhile, has adapted: it grew by 4.9% in 2024 and by 1% in 2025 (Trading Economics, 6/2/2026).
- **Industry.** In Germany, output of energy-intensive industries fell by 15.2% between February 2022 and March 2026 (Destatis via Clean Energy Wire, 15/5/2026).

THE TARIFF DEAL

In July 2025, in Scotland, the Union accepted a US tariff of 15% on most of its goods. In return it removed its tariffs on US industrial goods and promised energy purchases worth $750 billion over three years (Reuters via BBC Bermuda, 28/7/2025). In February 2026 the US Supreme Court struck down the legal instrument Trump had used for the tariffs, and the European Parliament suspended its examination of the deal (European Parliament, 23/2/2026). In June it approved it anyway, with 440 votes in favour, adding clauses to suspend it if Washington does not keep its side of the bargain (Confectionery Production, 16/6/2026).

AT THE PEACE TABLE

On 15 August 2025 Trump met Putin in Alaska, without Europeans. Three days later von der Leyen, Macron, Merz, Meloni, Stubb and Britain's Starmer flew to Washington to stand beside Zelensky (Il Sole 24 Ore). The pattern has stayed the same: the US envoys Witkoff and Kushner negotiate with Moscow and with Kyiv; at the Kyiv talks of 6 September 2026 the national security advisers of France, the United Kingdom and Germany took part in only one session (House of Commons Library, 15/9/2026).

On 9 October Trump announced a deal with Moscow for the sale of more than 300,000 tonnes of Russian diesel; European governments criticised it. The same day Putin told him that an immediate resumption of negotiations was unlikely (Al Jazeera, 10/10/2026).

According to a Washington Post columnist, citing an anonymous US official and an anonymous European diplomat, the United States and the Europeans are preparing a joint plan: a truce along the front line, security guarantees for Kyiv, reconstruction funds and a large energy deal that would bring cheap Russian oil and gas back to Europe, with a timetable for lifting sanctions (Meduza, 14/10/2026). No government has confirmed it.

The European Council of 15 and 16 October reaffirmed that "the path to peace in Ukraine cannot be decided without Ukraine" and called on Russia to agree to an immediate and unconditional

ceasefire. It "regretted" the temporary lifting by the United States of sanctions on Russian diesel and promised new sanctions. The conclusions contain no European negotiating initiative (European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026). Zelensky asked the Union for an extra €70 billion for 2027; leaders asked the Commission to set out options, and von der Leyen said Europe cannot cover it alone (Euronews, 16/10/2026).

WHAT WORKED

Ukraine has not fallen, and since 2025 it has held mainly thanks to European money. Sanctions have been adopted unanimously 22 times. More than four million refugees have received protection. And after the 2020 recovery fund, joint debt was used again, this time to support a country at war.

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Condemning the invasion was a duty, and it remains one. But for us diplomacy comes first, always: it is the first duty the UN Charter imposes on anyone in a dispute. Europe put it last. It let the 2022 attempts drop, never opened a channel of its own with Moscow and handed the negotiation to Washington. Moscow, for its part, now refuses to negotiate until it has taken Donbas: the duty applies to it too. The conclusions of the 16 October summit confirm it: a ceasefire demanded of Russia, new sanctions, new money, and no European proposal for reaching a negotiation.

Instead of diplomacy, the Union chose sanctions and aid. Economic sanctions also hit people who bear no blame: Russian citizens who did not decide the war, and European citizens who paid more for energy. Meanwhile Russia's war economy has adapted. The aid went to a government whose scandals came to light only thanks to bodies that the same government had tried to weaken. So Europe pays, but others decide.

The plan being discussed in these weeks shows it clearly. If it were confirmed, Russian gas would return to Europe, but on terms negotiated in Washington: the same supplies that Europe gave up on principle would come back inside a deal it did not write.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The Commission's options for covering the €70 billion Kyiv has requested for 2027.

- The three-way talks between the United States, Ukraine and Russia, and whether the plan reported by the Washington Post is confirmed.
- The opening of the two remaining clusters in Ukraine's accession negotiations.
- NABU's investigation into Operation Midas and the possible extradition of Mindich.

Sources: Council of the EU, 12/10/2026 · AP, 19/12/2025 · Eunews, 23/6/2025 · Grosswald, SAFE tracker · Eurostat via Eunews, 10/9/2026 · Euronews, 10/7/2026 · European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026 · Foreign Affairs, 16/4/2024 · The National Interest · House of Commons Library, 15/9/2026 · Meduza, 14/10/2026 · Kiel Institute via Euronews, 11/2/2026 · Kiel Institute, 13/8/2026 · Euromaidan Press, 31/7/2025 · Euromaidan Press, 28/11/2025 · Eurostat · Bruegel · UN, note by the Secretary-General · Trading Economics, 6/2/2026 · Destatis via Clean Energy Wire, 15/5/2026 · Reuters via BBC Bermuda, 28/7/2025 · European Parliament, 23/2/2026 · Confectionery Production, 16/6/2026 · Il Sole 24 Ore · Al Jazeera, 10/10/2026 · Euronews, 16/10/2026

Why Ukraine and not Sudan

IN BRIEF

- To help Ukraine, Europe has spent more than **€200 billion** since 2022, in weapons, money for the state and humanitarian aid. For Sudan, the help is humanitarian only.
- On humanitarian aid alone, Ukraine is not favoured: in 2026 it receives about **€20** per person in need, the Palestinian territories about **€60**, Sudan and Yemen about **€5**.
- The difference lies in political choices: only in Ukraine has Europe sent **weapons**, paid the **state budget** and listed about **4,600** individuals and entities.
- Ukraine matters for concrete reasons: it borders four EU countries, used to export 10% of the world's wheat and hosts Europe's largest nuclear power plant.
- For Washington the aim was stated openly: "We want to see Russia weakened."

THE QUESTION

Why Ukraine and not Sudan? In the previous pieces of this series we saw how much Europe has spent after 2022 and how the war came about. Here we put Ukraine next to three other conflicts, Sudan, Gaza and the West Bank, and Yemen, and measure them with the same yardstick. First, though, let us see what Ukraine is worth, and to whom.

WHAT UKRAINE IS WORTH

To Europe. Ukraine borders four EU countries: Poland, Slovakia, Hungary and Romania. Since the Helsinki Final Act of 1975, European security has rested on the principle that borders are not changed by force. Before the war Ukraine exported about 10% of the wheat and 15% of the maize sold worldwide (farmdoc daily, University of Illinois, 24/2/2023). On its territory stands Zaporizhzhia, Europe's largest nuclear power plant, with six reactors: it is in Russian hands and has produced no electricity since 11 September 2022 (Interfax, 17/4/2026).

To Russia. In 1997 Zbigniew Brzezinski, a former US national security adviser, wrote in *The Grand Chessboard* that without Ukraine Russia ceases to be a Eurasian empire. Crimea hosts the base of Russia's Black Sea fleet. Moscow still demands that the "root causes" of the conflict be addressed: NATO enlargement and the protection of Russian speakers (House of Commons Library, 15/9/2026).

To the United States. On 25 April 2022, in Poland, Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin said: "We want to see Russia weakened to a degree that it can't do the kinds of things it has done in invading Ukraine" (Axios, 25/4/2022). On 30 April 2025 Washington and Kyiv signed a minerals deal: a joint fund receives half of the revenue from new mining, oil and gas projects, and future US military aid counts as the US share (CSIS, 1/5/2025). The previous pieces showed the rest: American gas and weapons sold to Europe.

THE SAME YARDSTICK: HUMANITARIAN AID

To compare conflicts we need consistent numbers: same source, same year, same unit. The first table compares the needs estimated by the UN for 2026 with the humanitarian aid allocated by the European Commission in the same year.

	Ukraine	Sudan	Palestinian territories	Yemen
People in need of aid in 2026	10.8 million	33.7 million	3.6 million	23.1 million
European Commission humanitarian aid in 2026	€220 million	€162 million	over €217 million	€120 million (2025)
Euros per person in need	about €20	about €5	about €60	about €5

Sources: UN, Global Humanitarian Overview 2026, for Sudan and for the other countries as reported by Concern; European Commission country pages for Ukraine, Sudan, Palestine and Yemen. For Yemen the 2026 figure has not yet been published; we use 2025. For Sudan we count only aid inside the country, not aid for refugees in neighbouring countries.

On humanitarian aid, then, Europe does not favour Ukraine. Those who receive least, by far, are Sudan and Yemen: the two crises with the most people in need.

THE SAME YARDSTICK: POLITICAL CHOICES

The difference lies in what Europe does beyond humanitarian aid.

	Ukraine	Sudan	Israel and Palestine	Yemen
Weapons	€75.2 billion supplied by the EU and member states	EU arms embargo since 1994	member states sell to Israel	member states have sold to the Saudi-led coalition
Money for the state	€43.3 billion in financial assistance, plus the €90 billion loan for 2026-27	none	up to €1.6 billion for the Palestinian Authority for 2025-27	about €500 million in development aid since 2015
EU sanctions	about 4,600 Russian individuals and entities	18 individuals and 8 entities, from both sides	21 violent settlers and organisations; no measures against the Israeli government; Hamas on the EU list of terrorist organisations	the Houthis, under a UN embargo adopted by the EU

Sources: Ukraine, Eunews on European Parliament data, 1/6/2026, AP, 19/12/2025, Council of the EU, 12/10/2026; Sudan, SIPRI and Dabanga, 29/1/2026; Israel and Palestine, The New Arab, 1/10/2025, European Commission, 14/4/2025, J Street, June 2026, Lovguiden, 30/7/2026; Yemen, Reuters via The New Arab and Council of the EU, 14/3/2022.

Two examples give the measure. Germany had authorised about €251 million in military exports to Israel between early 2024 and mid-2025; in August 2025 it suspended them for a few weeks, then resumed them (The New Arab, cited above). In 2023 Italy lifted the embargo on selling bombs and missiles to Saudi Arabia that it had introduced over the war in Yemen (Reuters, cited above).

The European Council of 15 and 16 October 2026 shows the same pattern in words. On Ukraine, the conclusions call for new sanctions against Russia and release €6.6 billion for weapons. On Gaza and the West Bank, they condemn settlement expansion and settler violence, warn companies against bidding for construction in the E1 area and call for Hamas to disarm, but provide for no measures against the Israeli government. On Yemen, they condemn the Houthis' attacks on Saudi Arabia and express solidarity with Riyadh, saying nothing about the Saudi-led coalition. Sudan is never mentioned (European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026).

THE DEAD

Death tolls are not in the tables because the sources measure different things. We give them one by one, saying what they count.

- **Ukraine:** at least 16,431 civilians killed between February 2022 and June 2026, counting only cases verified one by one by the UN (UN Human Rights Monitoring Mission, 14/7/2026). According to the monitor ACLED, in 2025 alone the war killed about 78,000 people, soldiers and civilians (Newsweek, on ACLED data).
- **Sudan:** about 80,000 deaths estimated in 2025 alone, according to a model by researchers at Uppsala and at PRIO in Oslo (The Conversation via Polity, 7/10/2026).
- **Gaza:** 73,001 dead since 7 October 2023 according to Gaza's health ministry, which does not distinguish between civilians and combatants; UN agencies consider its records generally reliable (AP via PBS, 14/6/2026).
- **Yemen:** 377,000 deaths estimated by UNDP by the end of 2021, including those from hunger and disease (Al Jazeera, 23/11/2021).

WHAT WORKED

European humanitarian aid does not follow alliances: per person, the Palestinian territories receive more than Ukraine. In April 2026, in Berlin, the EU and member states pledged more than €812 million for Sudan and its refugees (European Commission, 15/4/2026). And in Sudan, European sanctions hit both sides, the army and the Rapid Support Forces.

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

The principles are not false: the UN Charter applies in Ukraine as in Sudan, in Gaza as in Yemen. But Europe enforces them with all its strength only where they coincide with its own interests and with Washington's. In Ukraine they coincide: the Union's borders, grain, nuclear power, a rival to weaken. In Sudan and Yemen they do not, and there Europe sends aid, not policy. In Gaza the interests pull the other way, and European weapons keep reaching one of the parties.

International law is not an ideology to be used where it suits. Either it applies to everyone, or it becomes a flag. This site exists to demand that it apply to everyone: the same sanctions for whoever bombs civilians, whoever they are; the same diplomatic effort for every war; the same halt to arms for whoever violates humanitarian law.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The UN Global Humanitarian Overview 2027, in December, and how much of it Europe will fund.
- New entries in the EU sanctions regime on Sudan, extended on 9 October 2026 until 10 October 2027 with no additions (Lovguiden, 9/10/2026).
- The proposal to suspend the trade part of the EU-Israel Association Agreement.

Sources: farmdoc daily, University of Illinois, 24/2/2023 · Interfax, 17/4/2026 · House of Commons Library, 15/9/2026 · Axios, 25/4/2022 · CSIS, 1/5/2025 · Sudan · Concern · Ukraine · Sudan · Palestine · Yemen · Eunews on European Parliament data, 1/6/2026 · AP, 19/12/2025 · Council of the EU, 12/10/2026 · SIPRI · Dabanga, 29/1/2026 · The New Arab, 1/10/2025 · European Commission, 14/4/2025 · J Street, June 2026 · Lovguiden, 30/7/2026 · Reuters via The New Arab · Council of the EU, 14/3/2022 · European Council, conclusions of 16/10/2026 · UN Human Rights Monitoring Mission, 14/7/2026 · Newsweek, on ACLED data · The Conversation via Polity, 7/10/2026 · AP via PBS, 14/6/2026 · Al Jazeera, 23/11/2021 · European Commission, 15/4/2026 · Lovguiden, 9/10/2026

Who really decides Europe's choices

IN BRIEF

- **The dollar is a real lever.** In 2014 France's BNP Paribas paid $8.9 billion for breaking US sanctions; in 2023 Europe's vehicle for trading with Iran was shut down after a single transaction.
- On 9 October 2026 the United States sanctioned the **International Criminal Court**. Europe protests, but does not use the law that would let it protect its own companies.
- **The bond spread, by contrast, had a European hand.** In 2011 the letter to Italy was signed by the ECB of Trichet and Draghi; according to then US Treasury Secretary Geithner, European officials asked Washington to help them bring down Berlusconi, and Washington refused.
- On **taxes**, in 2025 the G7 exempted US multinationals from the global minimum tax. But Europe also fined Apple, Meta and Google despite Trump's threats.
- On **security**, the European commissioner who negotiated the tariff deal said it openly: "It's not only about the trade, it's about security, it's about Ukraine."

THE CLAIM TO BE TESTED

One claim comes up often: Europe does not really decide. Washington steers it without needing to give orders, through the dollar, interest rates, rating agencies and big funds. A government that gets in the way can be brought to its knees in a few days.

In this piece of the series, which follows the one on the choices after 2022, we test the claim lever by lever. For each one we look for documented cases where it worked and cases where Europe resisted. One rule, as always: a proven interest is not proof of a cause.

FIRST LEVER: THE DOLLAR AND SANCTIONS

The dollar is still the world's leading currency: it makes up 56.7% of central bank reserves (IMF, 30/9/2026). Anyone doing business in dollars passes through the American system, and that is why Washington can punish even those who break sanctions decided by it alone.

The best-known case is French. In June 2014 BNP Paribas pleaded guilty before a New York court and paid $8.9 billion for having evaded, between 2004 and 2012, US sanctions on Sudan,

Cuba and Iran (Al Jazeera, 30/6/2014).

When the United States left the nuclear deal with Iran, France, Germany and the United Kingdom created INSTEX, a company to trade with Tehran without going through the dollar. In four years it made a single transaction, a delivery of medical goods in early 2020. In March 2023 it was wound up; European governments blamed Iran, which had rejected its proposals (UK Government, 9/3/2023).

The most recent case concerns international law. On 9 October 2026 Washington sanctioned the International Criminal Court as such, after the arrest warrant for Netanyahu and the investigation into US troops in Afghanistan. European banks and insurers that work with the Court risk secondary sanctions. 58 MEPs asked the Commission to activate the "Blocking Statute", the European law that forbids companies from applying foreign sanctions and allows them to claim damages (Euronews, 14/10/2026). For now the Commission prefers diplomacy (EUobserver, 14/10/2026); on 16 October the European Council said it "deeply regrets" the sanctions, but its conclusions do not mention the Blocking Statute (European Council, 16/10/2026). We have written about the long siege of the Court here.

The counter-example. In May 2021 the Biden administration waived sanctions on the Nord Stream 2 company and its chief executive, while acknowledging they had engaged in sanctionable activity, so as not to break with Germany, which wanted the pipeline (Maritime Executive, 19/5/2021). When Berlin holds firm, Washington can give way.

SECOND LEVER: THE BOND SPREAD

Here the claim needs correcting. In the two hardest European debt crises, the decisive pressure came from Frankfurt and from European capitals.

Italy, 2011. On 5 August the European Central Bank, with the signatures of Jean-Claude Trichet and Mario Draghi, wrote to the Berlusconi government demanding precise and immediate measures: cuts, reforms, a balanced budget. ECB support for Italian bonds was tied to those demands. The letter was made public by Corriere della Sera on 29 September; Berlusconi resigned on 12 November (Wikipedia, Trichet-Draghi letter). In his memoir, then US Treasury Secretary Timothy Geithner wrote that in that autumn "European officials" asked Washington to help them bring down Berlusconi, including by refusing support for an IMF rescue. Washington refused: "We cannot have blood on our hands" (The Local, 14/5/2014).

Greece, 2015. On 28 June, on the eve of the referendum on the creditors' plan, the ECB refused to increase emergency liquidity for Greek banks. The Tsipras government closed the banks and imposed limits on withdrawals (NPR, 28/6/2015).

The counter-example. The same ECB ended the spread crisis. On 26 July 2012 Draghi said in London: "The ECB is ready to do whatever it takes to preserve the euro." Rates for the weaker countries fell (Quartz). And markets do not only punish those who disobey Washington: in September 2022 Liz Truss's United Kingdom, one of America's most loyal allies, announced unfunded tax cuts; sterling hit a record low, the Bank of England had to intervene and Truss resigned after 44 days (CNBC, 21/10/2022).

On rating agencies and big investment funds we found no documented evidence of direct pressure on a European government on Washington's behalf. That is why we do not count them among the proven levers.

THIRD LEVER: TAXES

On 28 June 2025 the G7 countries, including Germany, France and Italy, agreed to exempt US multinationals from the 15% global minimum tax agreed at the OECD: they will pay only in the United States. The deal came while Congress was debating a "revenge tax" against countries that applied the minimum tax to American companies (Reuters via Arab News, 28/6/2025).

But the picture is not one-way. In September 2024 the EU Court of Justice ruled that Ireland had granted Apple illegal state aid and that Apple had to pay back more than €13 billion in taxes. Defending Apple, alongside the company, was the Irish government (Silicon Republic, 10/9/2024). The tax competition that favours multinationals was, in this case, the work of a European country.

The counter-example. In April 2025 the Commission fined Apple €500 million and Meta €200 million under the new Digital Markets Act (AFP via Arab News, 23/4/2025). In September 2025 it fined Google €2.95 billion; Trump threatened trade retaliation (Euronews, 6/9/2025). The fines were imposed all the same.

FOURTH LEVER: SECURITY

This is the most explicit lever. On 28 July 2025, defending the deal that accepted 15% US tariffs, EU trade commissioner Maroš Šefčovič said: "It's not only about the trade, it's about security, it's about Ukraine" (IBTimes, 28/7/2025). The previous pieces showed the rest: 58% of the weapons imported by European NATO countries come from the United States, and European governments buy American weapons for Kyiv.

The counter-example. In 2008, at the NATO summit in Bucharest, Germany and France blocked the membership path for Ukraine and Georgia that Washington wanted to start (NATO, 3/4/2008).

AND THE US DEBT?

It is also said that the United States needs Europe to finance its debt. The numbers say otherwise. In July 2026 US Treasury securities in foreign hands were worth about $9,250 billion (Trading Economics, on Treasury data), less than a quarter of a debt that passed $40,000 billion in August (Africanews, 20/8/2026). The largest foreign holders are Japan, the United Kingdom and China. US debt is financed mostly at home.

WHAT WORKED

When Europe acts together, with common rules and institutions, it gets results even against American interests: the fines on the big digital platforms were imposed despite the threats, the Apple ruling is final, the ECB stopped speculation against the euro in 2012, and in 2021 Berlin got Washington to waive sanctions on the Nord Stream 2 company.

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

The original claim is half true. Washington has real, documented levers: the dollar, with which it punishes those who trade with its enemies, and security, which it openly trades for commercial and tax concessions. The sanctions on the International Criminal Court show it starkly: they hit a court that Europe wanted and funds.

But the other half of the claim does not hold. The spread that bent Italy in 2011 and Greece in 2015 had a European address: Frankfurt and the European capitals. And the tax havens that favour multinationals are also inside the Union. Saying that America is in charge is true for one part; for the other part it is a convenient way of absolving Europe's ruling classes.

The point, for us, is another. When Europe uses the tools it has, it wins: the ECB and competition policy have shown it. The Blocking Statute has existed since 1996, and it has stayed in a drawer even now that sanctions are hitting the International Criminal Court. Dependence is not only imposed: in large part it is chosen, every time Europe gives up using what it has.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The Commission's decision on activating the Blocking Statute to protect the International Criminal Court.
- Implementation at the OECD of the exemption for US multinationals from the global minimum tax.

- Purchases of American weapons with European funds, and the share of European products in rearmament programmes.

Sources: IMF, 30/9/2026 · Al Jazeera, 30/6/2014 · UK Government, 9/3/2023 · Euronews, 14/10/2026 · EUobserver, 14/10/2026 · European Council, 16/10/2026 · Maritime Executive, 19/5/2021 · Wikipedia, Trichet-Draghi letter · The Local, 14/5/2014 · NPR, 28/6/2015 · Quartz · CNBC, 21/10/2022 · Reuters via Arab News, 28/6/2025 · Silicon Republic, 10/9/2024 · AFP via Arab News, 23/4/2025 · Euronews, 6/9/2025 · IBTimes, 28/7/2025 · NATO, 3/4/2008 · Trading Economics, on Treasury data · Africanews, 20/8/2026

8/9 · ANALYSIS · 18 OCTOBER 2026

Was Nord Stream a military objective?

IN BRIEF

- On 26 September 2022 a series of explosions ripped open three of the four Nord Stream lines, in the economic waters of Denmark and Sweden. Since 14 October 2026 a former Ukrainian officer, Serhii Kuznietsov, has been on trial in Hamburg. He denies any involvement.
- The defence also argues something else: the pipeline was a legitimate military objective, "a weapon in the hands of the Russians". In 2025 a Polish judge said something similar, speaking of a "just war".
- American and Russian theories have also circulated: no investigation has confirmed them. According to Der Spiegel and the Wall Street Journal, the CIA knew of the Ukrainian plan and in June 2022 asked for it to be stopped.
- Under the law of war, an object is a military objective only if it makes an "effective contribution to military action" and destroying it offers a definite military advantage. When it was hit, Nord Stream was carrying no gas, was partly owned by European companies and lay in the waters of neutral countries.
- Germany's Federal Court of Justice has already written, in a ruling on pre-trial detention, that it was civilian infrastructure. The same criteria led the International Criminal Court to seek the arrest of Russia's top military commanders for the strikes on Ukraine's power grid.
- Our assessment: by the same yardstick, the military-objective argument does not hold. The justice of a war does not make every blow lawful. It is for the court, however, to establish who acted and on whose orders.

THE QUESTION

We wrote about Nord Stream in the first piece of this series, on energy, to explain how Europe's dependence changed. Here we ask two questions. Who destroyed it, on the evidence available? And if it really was Ukraine, as the prosecution in Hamburg argues, was it a lawful act of war?

The question matters beyond this trial. It concerns all energy infrastructure: pipelines, cables, refineries, power plants. And it concerns the yardstick Europe uses to judge attacks, depending

on who carries them out. The charges against Kuznietsov have yet to be proven: we reason on the prosecution's hypothesis, not on established guilt.

THE FACTS

The explosions. On 26 September 2022 a series of explosions damaged three of the four lines of Nord Stream 1 and 2, at a depth of about 80 metres near the Danish island of Bornholm (Intellinews). The explosions took place outside territorial waters, but within the exclusive economic zones of Denmark and Sweden. Neither country was at war.

The state of the pipelines. Nord Stream 1 was no longer carrying gas: Moscow had cut off supplies at the end of August 2022. Nord Stream 2 had never entered service, because in February 2022 Germany had suspended its certification (AP via ClickOnDetroit, 26/2/2024). Both, however, contained gas, which escaped into the sea.

The owners. Nord Stream 1 was 51% owned by Russia's Gazprom. The rest belonged to four European companies: Germany's Wintershall Dea and E.ON (15.5% each), the Dutch Gasunie and France's Engie (9% each) (Euronews, 27/9/2022).

The damage to the environment. According to a study published in Nature, the lines released up to 485,000 tonnes of methane: four to five times the Aliso Canyon leak in California in 2015 (Queen Mary University of London).

The investigations. Sweden and Denmark closed their investigations in February 2024 without charging anyone. Germany went ahead. Kuznietsov, arrested in Italy in August 2025, was handed over to Germany in November after Italy's Court of Cassation gave the green light (Maritime Executive, 28/11/2025). The trial opened on 14 October 2026 before the Higher Regional Court in Hamburg. According to the prosecution, Kuznietsov and other Ukrainian military personnel acted "by order of Ukrainian state agencies" to permanently disrupt gas supplies. The defendant denies it and did not speak in court (Courthouse News, 14/10/2026). There are four charges: a war crime (attacking protected civilian objects) and three ordinary offences, namely causing an explosion, destroying structures and disrupting public services (Diplomacy and Law, 13/10/2026). Ukraine's Prosecutor General's Office says it found no evidence of state involvement.

A second suspect. Ukrainian diver Volodymyr Zhuravlyov was arrested in Poland in 2025. On 17 October 2025 a Warsaw court refused to hand him over to Germany and released him (Notes from Poland, 17/10/2025). Arrested again in Croatia in August 2026, in September a Croatian court authorised his extradition; his lawyers have announced an appeal (Euromaidan Press, 24/9/2026).

WHO WAS BEHIND IT: THE THEORIES

Over these four years three different accounts have circulated, alongside the German prosecution's. We compared them with the same questions: who put them forward, what they rest on, who denies them, what investigations have made of them.

	United States	Russia	Ukraine, with the CIA informed	Ukraine (German prosecution)
Who put it forward	Journalist Seymour Hersh, February 2023	German news site t-online, March 2023	Wall Street Journal (August 2024) and Der Spiegel (February 2026)	German Federal Prosecutor
What it rests on	A single anonymous source	Russian military ships in the area a few days before, with position signals switched off	Anonymous sources, including one person who says he took part	Judicial investigation: the rented yacht, false identity documents
Who denies it	White House and CIA	Moscow blames the West	CIA ("completely false"); Zaluzhny ("a provocation")	Kyiv; the defendant
What investigations have made of it	None has confirmed it	None has confirmed it	Partly matches the German investigation	Trial under way in Hamburg

Sources for the table: Hersh and the denials (Snopes, 10/2/2023); the Russian ships (t-online, 25/3/2023); the Wall Street Journal (Ukrainska Pravda, 15/8/2024); Der Spiegel (taz, 19/2/2026); the charges and the false documents, from the German Federal Court of Justice ruling cited below.

A few more details, because each theory has a strong point and a weak one.

United States. Hersh wrote that US Navy divers, with Norway's help, planted the charges in June 2022 during a NATO exercise. In its favour, people cite a remark by Joe Biden on 7 February 2022: if Russia invades, "there will no longer be a Nord Stream 2. We will bring an end to it." But the whole account rests on one person nobody can verify. In March 2023 Russia asked the UN Security Council for an international inquiry: only Russia, China and Brazil voted in favour, while the other twelve members abstained (Arab News, 28/3/2023).

Russia. The theory of self-sabotage rests on movements of Russian ships reconstructed from satellite images and anonymous sources. The article itself uses the conditional: no ship was identified with certainty and no investigator has confirmed the lead.

Ukraine, with the CIA informed. This is the most detailed account. According to Der Spiegel, in spring 2022 the Ukrainian group presented the plan to CIA contacts, who at first did not object. In June Dutch intelligence reportedly warned the CIA and German intelligence; at that point Washington reportedly asked Kyiv to stop, without success. The operation, costing about $300,000, was reportedly paid for by a private businessman. The two investigations, however, disagree on one point: for the Wall Street Journal, Zelensky had approved the plan and then asked for it to be stopped; for Der Spiegel he had not been informed, and the final word came from then commander-in-chief Valerii Zaluzhny.

One thing is certain: the theories about the United States and Russia have, to date, found no confirmation in a court of law. The Ukrainian trail is the only one to have reached trial.

WHAT THE LAW OF WAR SAYS

The central rule is Article 52 of the First Additional Protocol to the Geneva Conventions. Attacks must be limited to military objectives. An object is a military objective only if **two conditions are met together**: by its nature, location, purpose or use it makes "an effective contribution to military action"; and its destruction offers, in the circumstances ruling at the time, "a definite military advantage". In case of doubt, an object normally used for civilian purposes is presumed civilian (First Protocol, official text, Swiss Confederation).

The same Protocol lays down a principle that matters a great deal here: the rules apply to everyone, "without any adverse distinction based on the nature or origin of the armed conflict or on the causes espoused" by the parties. The law of war does not ask who is right in the war. It asks how the war is fought. It applies to the aggressor and to the victim of aggression alike.

Experts are divided on one point: whether objects that **finance** a war, such as oil and gas exports, can become military objectives. The United States takes the broadest reading, but even for Washington an object that generates revenue is not, in itself, a military objective: a concrete link with operations is needed (Lieber Institute, West Point, 7/7/2026). According to a number of scholars, most states take a narrower view.

THE TWO ARGUMENTS

The defence. In court, lawyer Nicola Canestrini called the pipelines "a weapon in the hands of the Russians" and asked for the charges to be dismissed (Courthouse News). The argument is

that Moscow used gas to blackmail Europe and to finance the war.

The Polish judge. In refusing Zhuravlyov's extradition, judge Dariusz Łubowski said Ukraine's defence is a "just war", and that blowing up the enemy's infrastructure in such a war "is not sabotage, but military action": "justified, rational and just". Prime Minister Donald Tusk commented: "The case is closed" (Notes from Poland).

The German Federal Court of Justice. On 10 December 2025, ruling on Kuznietsov's pre-trial detention, the Federal Court of Justice wrote that the pipelines were civilian infrastructure and therefore not a legitimate target. It also ruled out combatant privilege: it does not cover military personnel who act covertly, without distinguishing themselves from civilians. And it found "strong grounds" to believe that the operation was decided and directed by the Ukrainian state. It was a provisional assessment, not a verdict (LTO, 16/1/2026).

The scholars. As early as 2023, legal scholar Alexander Lott of the Norwegian Centre for the Law of the Sea had reached the same conclusion: a doubtful military objective, because the pipelines also served Germany, which was not at war, and they carried no gas when they were hit. He added that the attack failed to take account of the marine environment (University of Tromsø, 21/11/2023).

THE SAME YARDSTICK

To see whether the judgment changes depending on who strikes, we compared three campaigns against energy, with the same questions.

	Ukraine's power grid	Russian refineries	Nord Stream
Who strikes	Russia	Ukraine	Ukraine, according to the German prosecution (Kyiv denies it)
Where	In Ukraine, a country at war	In Russia, a country at war	In Danish and Swedish waters, countries not at war
Did it serve the armed forces when it was hit?	In part: a grid with civilian and military use	In part: some supply the army, others export	No: no gas flowing, one line never in service
What courts or experts have said	The International Criminal Court sought the arrest of four senior Russian officers for attacks on civilian objects and excessive harm to civilians	Lawful for those that supply the army; for export facilities the call is "too close"	German Federal Court of Justice (provisionally): civilian infrastructure

Sources for the table: for the power grid, the International Criminal Court warrants against Kobylash and Sokolov (March 2024) and against Shoigu and Gerasimov (June 2024), for strikes between October 2022 and March 2023 (JusticeInfo, 25/6/2024); for the refineries, the Lieber Institute analysis; for Nord Stream, the German Federal Court of Justice ruling cited above.

The comparison says something simple: the same criteria that make Russia's strikes on Ukraine's power grid unlawful also weigh on Nord Stream, and weigh more heavily. Nord Stream is the case furthest from a military objective: it was not in use, it was not in a country at war and it was partly owned by companies from Ukraine's allies.

WHAT WORKED

European judicial cooperation worked, at least in part. Italy handed Kuznietsov over under the European arrest warrant, and a Croatian court authorised the surrender of the second suspect. Germany is trying in public a citizen of a country it supports with weapons and money, on a charge that implicates the Ukrainian state. The trial will allow the evidence to be tested in court, with the defence present.

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

By the same yardstick we apply to Russia, the military-objective argument does not hold. An idle pipeline, in the waters of countries not at war, partly European-owned, was making no effective contribution to Russian military action. Depriving Moscow of future revenue is not enough: if it were, every income-producing asset would become a target, in every war. And the damage to the environment, hundreds of thousands of tonnes of methane, fell on everyone.

The Warsaw judge's "just war" conflates two questions that the law deliberately keeps apart: why a war is fought and how it is fought. Ukraine has the right to defend itself. That does not make every blow lawful, just as the defence claimed by Moscow does not make it lawful to bomb Ukraine's power stations in winter. Whoever accepts the argument for Nord Stream must accept it when the other side uses it too.

Then there is a European point. If the accounts by Der Spiegel and the Wall Street Journal are true, Dutch, German and American intelligence knew of the plan three months in advance: it is legitimate to ask what they did to stop it, and why they failed. An infrastructure in which German, Dutch and French companies had invested was destroyed; the head of an EU government welcomed the release of one suspect, while Germany is trying another. If the prosecution's case is confirmed, Europe will have to say clearly what it has so far avoided saying: that even a country under attack, and supported by Europe, is bound by the rules Europe asks others to respect. But Kuznietsov's responsibility, and that of the Ukrainian state, will be established by the court, not by us.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The next hearings in Hamburg, scheduled until December, and the testimony of the military commanders called by the defence.
- Whether the trial brings out what American, Dutch and German intelligence knew, and when.
- Whether the court finds the war crime proven, or only the ordinary offences.
- Zhuravlyov's appeal in Croatia and his possible surrender to Germany.
- Attacks on energy in the ongoing war, by both sides, with winter approaching.

Sources: Intellinews · AP via ClickOnDetroit, 26/2/2024 · Euronews, 27/9/2022 · Queen Mary University of London · Maritime Executive, 28/11/2025 · Courthouse News, 14/10/2026 · Diplomacy

and Law, 13/10/2026 · Notes from Poland, 17/10/2025 · Euromaidan Press, 24/9/2026 · Snopes, 10/2/2023 · t-online, 25/3/2023 · Ukrainska Pravda, 15/8/2024 · taz, 19/2/2026 · Arab News, 28/3/2023 · First Protocol, official text, Swiss Confederation · Lieber Institute, West Point, 7/7/2026 · LTO, 16/1/2026 · University of Tromsø, 21/11/2023 · JusticeInfo, 25/6/2024

9/9 · ANALYSIS · 18 OCTOBER 2026

Immigration: the doors Europe closes and the ones it opens

IN BRIEF

- At the summit on 16 October Denmark, Italy and Poland accused Spain of attracting migrants by regularising people already in the country. They did not get the wording they wanted.
- Irregular arrivals are falling sharply, but more people are dying: on the route to Italy, in proportion to arrivals, deaths have almost tripled.
- Europe is betting on returns, including to centres outside its borders on the Italian model in Albania. So far that model has cost a great deal and returned very few people.
- In Italy fear has grown faster than crime. Foreigners are over-represented among those reported for crimes, but the decisive factor is lacking papers: those who get them commit far fewer crimes.
- Our assessment: immigration is used as a political lever and the fear is real. But laws that produce undocumented people feed the very problem they claim to fight.

THE NEWS

At the European Council of 15 and 16 October immigration divided governments more than any other issue. The target was Spain, which is granting a residence permit to about 600,000 people already living in the country without papers.

Denmark, Italy and Poland asked for the conclusions to say that "pull factors" must be reduced. It is a phrase that comes up often: it means anything that, according to those who use it, draws people to a particular country, such as the hope of being regularised. Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen put it like this: "You arrive in a country illegally, and suddenly you can obtain permission to stay there legally" (EU Perspectives, 16/10/2026). Madrid replies that regularising people who already work off the books brings work and contributions into the open, and moves no one to other countries. French President Emmanuel Macron closed the discussion like this: when everyone goes back to national solutions, "we are ineffective" (Euronews, 16/10/2026).

The request did not pass. Regularisation remains a choice for each government. The conclusions only ask the Commission to prepare rules for emergencies, including cases where a

hostile state pushes migrants towards Europe's borders to put them under pressure, as in Ceuta at the end of July (European Council, 16/10/2026; on Ceuta, our piece). The issue returns in December.

FEWER ARRIVALS, MORE DEATHS

Irregular arrivals in the EU fell by more than a third in the first seven months of 2026; on the Central Mediterranean route, the one to Italy, they more than halved (Frontex, August 2026).

Deaths, however, are not falling. On the same route the dead and missing rose from 844 to 996 compared with last year (UNRIC, on IOM data, 17/9/2026). In proportion to arrivals, by our calculation, that is almost three times as many. Fewer people arrive, but for those who set out the journey has become far more dangerous. And according to the IOM, the UN migration agency, "nearly every death and disappearance at sea is preventable".

THE EU'S CHOICES

Common rules, little solidarity. Since 12 June the Pact on Migration and Asylum has been in force (our piece). For the first time all 27 follow the same rules to examine asylum applications. The Pact also provided for solidarity: the less exposed countries were to take in some of the applicants arriving in Italy, Greece or Spain, or pay. For 2026 states pledged less than half of the places foreseen; Hungary and Slovakia none (Euronews, 10/6/2026). Those on the front line remain, in practice, alone.

Returns, including abroad. The new return regulation, agreed in June, allows states to detain for up to two years people who must leave Europe and to send them to "return hubs" in countries outside the EU (Council of the EU, 1/6/2026). The problem it wants to solve is real: today less than a third of those ordered to leave actually do so.

Paying those who stop departures. The EU has given Tunisia more than €100 million to stop boats and control its borders. Humanitarian and human rights organisations report violent interceptions, torture and people abandoned in the desert at the border (Human Rights Watch, 16/7/2026). Departures fall, but the human cost moves to where Europe does not look.

And meanwhile it looks for workers. Europe is ageing and by 2050 most of its countries will have fewer people of working age (EUobserver, on Eurostat data). So the Italian government, one of the toughest on irregular arrivals, has planned almost 500,000 entries of foreign workers over three years, for the "indispensable labour" that companies cannot find (Sky TG24, 30/6/2025). Spain has chosen to give papers to those already in the country (Euro Weekly News, 17/10/2026). They are two different roads towards the same need.

FEAR AND SECURITY IN ITALY

In Italy immigration is discussed mainly as a security problem, and fear has grown fast: in four years security has risen from tenth to second place among Italians' concerns. But fear also depends on how people vote: irregular immigration worries more than four in ten centre-right voters and just over one in ten on the centre-left (Open, on an Ipsos Doxa poll, 11/10/2026). The same reality, seen from two camps, produces different fears.

The data say two things, and they must be held together. Reported crimes fell in 2025. And foreigners are more than a third of the people reported or arrested, while being less than a tenth of the population: the disproportion exists, especially for theft, robbery and drug dealing (Open, on Interior Ministry data, 12/10/2026).

What explains it? Not origin, but condition. In 2007 Italy allocated work permits through a "click day": those who sent the application first got one, those who arrived a few minutes later did not. Two groups of people identical in everything but luck. Economist Paolo Pinotti followed them: those who had obtained the permit had, a year later, committed less than half as many serious crimes as the others (Cato Institute, summary of the study). With papers you can work legally, rent a home, have something to lose if you go wrong. Without them, there is undeclared work and often the street.

And undocumented people do not only come by sea: laws produce them too. In Italy seven asylum applications out of ten are rejected (Il Fatto Quotidiano, on ISMU data, 26/2/2026). Those who are refused, but not returned because their country will not take them back, stay here without papers. The unease many see in some neighbourhoods of big cities also stems from this: people who can neither work legally nor be sent home.

THE ALBANIA MODEL

The answer governments rely on most is return centres, including abroad. The model is Italian. The two centres built in Albania were meant to examine asylum applications quickly; judges blocked the detentions and since March 2025 one of the two has become a return centre (Il Post, 11/6/2026).

The results are far from the promises. The government expected about 3,000 people a month; about 500 have passed through in total, at a cost of more than €670 million (Euronews, 26/8/2026). Returns, according to associations, number about ninety, and all took place after the people had been brought back to Italy; the Interior Ministry does not publish its figures. The reason is the same as for the centres in Italy: to return someone, their country must agree to take them back, and with many countries there are no agreements.

The EU Court of Justice has yet to decide whether the model complies with EU law (our piece). But Europe has already decided to follow it. "Italy has shown the way and today Europe is following it," said Giorgia Meloni (Avvenire, 11/6/2026). Denmark, Austria, Germany, the Netherlands and Greece want the first transfers to a country outside the EU in 2027; the press points to Uganda and Rwanda (Euronews, 4/9/2026). The United Kingdom already tried with Rwanda: the plan was abandoned after four voluntary departures.

THE SAME YARDSTICK

The summit conclusions also recall the extension until 2028 of temporary protection for the 4.4 million Ukrainians living in the EU (Euromaidan Press, on Eurostat data, 12/8/2026). It is a tool that had existed since 2001 and had never been used, not even for Syrians in 2015 (Verfassungsblog, 10/3/2022). It works simply: those fleeing a given war immediately receive the right to live, work and study in the EU, without asylum applications one by one. Those fleeing Sudan, by contrast, find the desert, the sea and interceptions paid for by Europe (our piece on Ukraine and Sudan).

WHAT WORKED

Temporary protection gave millions of Ukrainians a regular life within days. The Pact provided common rules where before each country went its own way. And legal channels, Italian and Spanish, recognise a fact the debate often hides: Europe's economy needs these people.

OUR ASSESSMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Immigration is used as a political lever. The fear is real and must be respected: people living in a run-down neighbourhood need answers, not lectures. But the data say that what produces insecurity is not origin, it is irregular status. Laws that multiply the number of undocumented people without managing to return them feed the very problem they promise to solve.

The Albania model shows it: the crux of returns is not where a person is held, but whether their country agrees to take them back. A centre across the Adriatic costs more and does not return more people. That Europe wants to copy it even before the ruling shows how much the message counts for more than the result. Meanwhile arrivals fall, and the price is paid by those who die at sea, far from the cameras.

And it is inconsistent to accuse those who give papers to people already working of "attracting migrants", while looking for half a million workers abroad. With Ukrainians Europe showed

that welcoming people well is possible. Asking for the same yardstick for those fleeing other wars means applying the rules Europe has given itself: outsourcing does not erase the obligation, it only moves it to where it is harder to enforce (our manifesto).

WHAT TO WATCH

- The December summit and the emergency rules the Commission will present by the end of the year.
- The Court of Justice ruling on the Albania centres and the first agreement for a return hub outside the EU.
- The figures on deaths at sea at the end of the year.
- Crime figures for 2026, ahead of the Italian election campaign.

Sources: EU Perspectives, 16/10/2026 · Euronews, 16/10/2026 · European Council, 16/10/2026 · Frontex, August 2026 · UNRIC, on IOM data, 17/9/2026 · Euronews, 10/6/2026 · Council of the EU, 1/6/2026 · Human Rights Watch, 16/7/2026 · EUobserver, on Eurostat data · Sky TG24, 30/6/2025 · Euro Weekly News, 17/10/2026 · Open, on an Ipsos Doxa poll, 11/10/2026 · Open, on Interior Ministry data, 12/10/2026 · Cato Institute, summary of the study · Il Fatto Quotidiano, on ISMU data, 26/2/2026 · Il Post, 11/6/2026 · Euronews, 26/8/2026 · Avvenire, 11/6/2026 · Euronews, 4/9/2026 · Euromaidan Press, on Eurostat data, 12/8/2026 · Verfassungsblog, 10/3/2022

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